

| By Abhijit Dasgupta |

The Opposition may well have made the point "it's all for Bengal and *baaki sab kangaal* (penniless)". But it is not as if the entire country has been left *kangaal* with Railways Minister Mamata Banerjee rooting only for Bengal. The Railway Budget is definitely skewed in favour of West Bengal and not just in terms of new trains or investments. And it had to be, given the ambition of the Trinamool Congress to oust the Red Brigade from Writers' Building. Indeed, the Railway Budget in many ways is an attempt by Banerjee to paint herself out of the "anti-development corner". Ranging from her offer to work with the private sector in public-private partnerships to the idea of a 100-day deadline for clearing investment proposals, jobs-for-land in cases of land acquisition and a vision statement, the budget is a window to her thoughts on growth and development. Obviously, like charity, politics has to begin at home but the rest of the country need not feel left out. Bengal's bounty has been paramount but not to the extent expected. That could be largely because Banerjee got a rap on her knuckles from both Prime Minister Manmohan Singh and Finance Minister Pranab Mukherjee only recently, but she seems to have made good her losses by giving the budget a "sociable" face in Bengal as opposed to merely goodies being doled out. Also, in a token gesture to the Congress, she has announced that work on the coach factory in Rae Bareilly, Sonia Gandhi's constituency, will start within a year.

Banerjee seems to have been keen on wooing industry and bent on erasing the "destructive, anti-development" image she has been given by the Left Front leaders. Even when she made her announcement on land acquisition, a sore point in Bengal with Nandigram and Singur having proved to be flashpoints recently, Banerjee has made it clear that there will be no "forcible takeovers" and that the Railways was willing to do



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By doling out sops for Bengal, Banerjee has treated the Rail Budget as her ticket to the Writers' Building

business with industry even in Singur if, and only if, the dispute over the 400 acres of land was first settled. "My business model is open otherwise. I invite all captains of industry to come forward and have their share of ready business," she said at the post-budget press conference. Add to this her offer of jobs for every family willing to give up land, and this could be Banerjee's winning formula.

There is both political and

economic design in her budget. For example, with her eyes firmly set on Kolkata and the corporation elections later this year, she has expanded the Metro Railways as a starting point with the network getting five new stations and the suburbs coming within the ambit of the Metro, turning hours of gruelling road travel into a few minutes. The Metro will see an increase of 55 per cent in outlay. Banerjee, in this, has played her cards